that it was seeing an unveiled woman rather than a man, identify the woman and retrieve her cellphone number. The system further ‘issued 133,174 SMS messages requiring the immobilisation of vehicles for two weeks, confiscated 2,000 cars, and referred more than 4,000 “repeat offenders” to the judiciary’.[35]

A 52-year-old woman named Maryam shared with Amnesty International her experience with the surveillance system. ‘The first time I received a warning for not wearing a headscarf while driving, I was passing through an intersection when a camera captured a photo and I immediately received a warning text message. The second time, I had done some shopping, and I was bringing the bags into the car, my scarf fell off, and I received a message noting that due to violating compulsory veiling laws, my car had been subjected to “systematic impoundment” for a period of fifteen days. I did not know what this meant. I asked around and found out through relatives that this meant I had to immobilise my car for fifteen days.’[36] Maryam’s testimony indicates that the AI sends its threatening messages within seconds, with no time for any human to review and authorise the procedure.

Penalties went far beyond the immobilisation or confiscation of vehicles. The Amnesty report from 26 July 2023 revealed that as a result of the mass surveillance effort ‘countless women have been suspended or expelled from universities, barred from sitting final exams, and denied access to banking services and public transport’.[37] Businesses that didn’t enforce the hijab law among their employees or customers also suffered. In one typical case, a woman employee at the Land of Happiness amusement park east of Tehran was photographed without a hijab, and the image circulated on social media. In punishment, the Land of Happiness was closed down by Iranian authorities.[38] Altogether, reported Amnesty, the authorities ‘shut down hundreds of tourist attractions, hotels, restaurants, pharmacies and shopping centres for not enforcing compulsory veiling laws.’[39]

In September 2023, on the anniversary of Mahsa Amini’s death, Iran’s parliament passed a new and stricter hijab bill. According to the new law, women who fail to wear the hijab can be punished by heavy fines and up to ten years in prison. They face additional penalties including confiscation of cars and communication devices, driving bans, deductions in salary and employment benefits, dismissal from work and prohibition from accessing